

SHORE INSTITUTE · SHORELINES

Morning Edition

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01

The Treaty You Tracked for Years Is Now Binding

Law

BBNJ entered into force in January. COP1 is where the rules get written.

The treaty you have spent years tracking through negotiation rounds is now binding law, and COP1's rules of procedure are where the seat you don't yet have gets decided.

STORY NOTES

The BBNJ Agreement, the treaty governing marine biodiversity beyond national jurisdiction, entered into force on 17 January 2026, six months after crossing the 60-ratification threshold in September 2025. Preparations are now underway for COP1, the agreement's first Conference of the Parties, where rules on marine protected area nomination, environmental impact assessment standards, and the Access and Benefit-Sharing mechanism for marine genetic resources get set.

For Seychelles, that puts the high seas MPA nomination procedure and the ABS mechanism into direct relevance for you: SHORE Institute's hydrosatial work maps exactly the kind of baseline data those nominations will need. The COP1 fight over voting thresholds and observer access decides whether a small state's technical input counts as much as a large one's.

<https://www.un.org/ola/en/news/ratification-agreement-under-united-nations-convention-law-sea-conservation-and-sustainable-use>

STORY ARTICLE

You have followed BBNJ since it was a working paper item at UNCLOS review meetings, and on 17 January 2026 it became binding law. Six months earlier, on 19 September 2025, Morocco's ratification crossed the 60-state threshold that triggered the 120-day countdown to entry into force. That threshold took nineteen years to reach, from the 2004 UN Ad Hoc Working Group that first raised the question of biodiversity beyond national jurisdiction to the finished text adopted in June 2023.

What changes now is not the ocean. It is the governance layer sitting over the roughly 64% of the ocean surface that lies beyond any state's 200-nautical-mile EEZ. That area has functioned for decades as a legal gap: too far out for national jurisdiction, and until now, without a binding instrument requiring environmental impact assessment or providing a route to designate marine protected areas. The BBNJ Agreement fills the gap with four tools: area-based management including high seas MPAs, environmental impact assessments for activities in ABNJ, a framework for sharing marine genetic resources and their benefits, and capacity-building and technology-transfer provisions aimed specifically at states like Seychelles that lack blue-water research fleets.

That capacity-building article is the one worth reading twice. It commits parties to a dedicated fund and to technology transfer "on fair and most favourable terms," language pushed hard by the G77 and specifically by small island states during the final negotiating sessions. SHORE Institute exists because Seychelles has 1.35 million square kilometres of EEZ and a hydrographic capacity built for a fraction of that. The BBNJ capacity-building mechanism is the first binding international commitment that treats that gap as something other states are obligated to help close, not simply acknowledge.

The immediate fight is not about the ocean either. It is about COP1, the first Conference of the Parties, where states set the rules of procedure that will govern everything after: how MPA nominations get evaluated, what evidentiary standard an EIA has to meet, how voting works when consensus fails. Rules of procedure sound procedural. They are not. A voting threshold set at two-thirds versus three-quarters decides whether a coalition of small states can block a decision on its own or needs to build a majority coalition every time. An MPA nomination process that requires extensive baseline data before submission favours states with existing survey capacity over ones building it. Seychelles was a vocal member of the High Ambition Coalition during BBNJ negotiations. COP1 is where that voice either gets institutionalised into procedure or diluted into a general debate slot.

There is a case for scepticism here, and it is worth naming directly. International environmental agreements have a poor record of translating text into enforcement, and BBNJ has no dedicated compliance body comparable to, say, the WTO's dispute settlement mechanism. Monitoring compliance in ABNJ, areas by definition outside any state's jurisdiction and largely outside anyone's surveillance capacity, is a genuinely hard problem the treaty text gestures at without solving. That is a fair criticism. It does not change what the treaty does provide: a legal basis, for the first time, to say an activity in the high seas requires an impact assessment at all. Before January 2026,

that requirement did not exist. A weak enforcement mechanism attached to a real legal obligation is still more than no obligation.

For Shorelines, the piece is not “BBNJ enters into force,” which every outlet from UN News to IISD has already covered. It is what COP1’s rules of procedure decide for a state like Seychelles specifically: whether the capacity-building fund has a disbursement mechanism SHORE could actually apply through, and whether the MPA nomination bar is calibrated to what a hydrospatially under-resourced SIDS can realistically submit. Track the DOALOS BBNJ page for the COP1 agenda once it is published, and get a submission or observer-status position in before the rules of procedure are locked, not after.

<https://www.un.org/ola/en/news/ratification-agreement-under-united-nations-convention-law-sea-conservation-and-sustainable-use>

 **ACTIONABLE — REGISTER NOW**

02

SHARE OF THE GLOBAL SEAFLOOR NOW MAPPED

28.7%

**Seabed 2030 Just Published the
Number. The Indo-Pacific Data**

Sprint Decides Whose Gap Closes Next.

Seabed 2030 just put a number on how much of the ocean floor remains unmapped, and the October data sprint in Kuala Lumpur is the room where Indian Ocean SIDS get to argue for their own waters being next.

STORY NOTES

28.7% of the world's ocean floor is now mapped under the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 project, announced by Executive Director Mitsuyuki Unno at the IHO Assembly in Monaco, with almost five million square kilometres added in the past year alone. The GEBCO_2026 Grid, the eighth grid release, published in April 2026, is downloadable now.

Registration is open for the Seabed 2030 Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting & Data Sprint, in Kuala Lumpur in October 2026. That is the regional forum where Indian Ocean and Pacific SIDS data gaps get raised directly, and where crowdsourced bathymetry from smaller states gets folded into the grid.

<https://seabed2030.org/>

STORY ARTICLE

28.7% is the headline. That is the share of the global ocean floor now mapped to modern standards under the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 project, announced this year by Executive Director Mitsuyuki Unno at the International Hydrographic Organization's Assembly in Monaco. Read the other way round, 71.3% of the seafloor, the largest unmapped surface on the planet, still is not. Almost five million square kilometres were added in the past twelve months, bringing the total mapped area to roughly 104 million square kilometres, more than two-thirds of the Earth's entire land surface, mapped as ocean floor alone.

The GEBCO_2026 Grid, the eighth iteration of the global bathymetric dataset the project produces, was published in April and is downloadable now. Every grid release is a snapshot of who contributed what, and where the remaining gaps sit. That matters for a very specific reason if you work in Seychelles waters: Seychelles' EEZ, at 1.35 million square kilometres, is disproportionately deep, remote, and under-surveyed relative to states with comparable coastlines and larger hydrographic budgets. Every percentage point Seabed 2030 adds either includes that gap or leaves it standing.

Registration is now open for the Seabed 2030 Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting & Data Sprint, in Kuala Lumpur in October 2026. Data sprints are where the project's Crowd Source Bathymetry initiative, essentially structured citizen and vessel-of-opportunity data submission, gets coordinated regionally rather than negotiated centrally. For a state without a dedicated survey fleet, this is the mechanism that actually works: fishing vessels, research charters, and even recreational transits submitting depth soundings that get QA'd and folded into the grid. It requires someone showing up to the room to make the case for prioritising a specific gap, and to get local data providers connected to the Seabed 2030 regional centre coordinating that ocean basin.

There is a real gap between the project's stated ambition, a fully mapped ocean floor by 2030, and its trajectory. At the current pace of roughly five million square kilometres a year, closing the remaining 71% would take well past the stated deadline unless the rate accelerates substantially, through vessel-of-opportunity programmes, satellite-derived bathymetry, or a funding step-change. The project has been candid about this gap in its own reporting rather than papering over it, which is more credible than most infrastructure-target announcements manage.

What this means for Shorelines is less about the global target and more about the regional mechanism. The Indo-Pacific data sprint is where Seychelles', and the wider Western Indian Ocean's, mapping gap gets either flagged for prioritisation or quietly left for the next grid cycle. SHORE Institute's hydrospatial work is exactly the kind of local capacity Seabed 2030 depends on for regions without national hydrographic offices funded at scale. Showing up, or getting a submission in through whichever regional coordination centre covers the Western Indian Ocean, is the actionable version of this story.

<https://seabed2030.org/>

⚡ CALL FOR PROPOSALS OPEN

03

Seychelles Is One of 25 States Eligible. One Slice Is Named for AI and Space Data.

Seychelles is one of the 25 Commonwealth SIDS eligible to apply for this fund directly, and the flagship allocation already includes AI and space data for climate action, the exact intersection SHORE works in.

STORY NOTES

The Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency have launched the Commonwealth Fund for SIDS, a \$10 million facility, with the first \$2 million tranche already disbursed. Governments of the 25 Commonwealth SIDS, Seychelles included, can apply for grants of up to \$200,000 for projects strengthening climate resilience, ocean health, and sustainable energy over the fund's five-year run.

A specific \$1 million slice of the first tranche is earmarked for two flagship projects: implementation of the Apia Commonwealth Ocean Declaration from CHOGM 2024 in Samoa, and delivery of AI and space data solutions for climate action. That second flagship is a direct match for SHORE's hydrospatial and GeoAI work.

Applications go through national government channels, not directly through NGOs, so this is a case for making it in front of the relevant Seychelles ministry now, not waiting for a public call announcement.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-collaboration-azerbaijan-launches-funding-sids>

STORY ARTICLE

Seychelles is one of twenty-five Commonwealth small island developing states now eligible to apply for the Commonwealth Fund for SIDS, a \$10 million facility the Secretariat launched with Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency. The first tranche, \$2 million, has already been disbursed. Grants run up to \$200,000 per project, over a five-year window, for work that strengthens climate resilience, improves ocean health, or expands sustainable energy access.

The detail worth sitting with is where \$1 million of that first tranche is going: two flagship allocations, one funding implementation of the Apia Commonwealth Ocean Declaration, the ocean commitment from the 2024 CHOGM in Samoa, the other funding "AI and space data solutions for climate action." That second line is not a generic climate adaptation category. It is a named commitment to fund exactly the kind of geospatial and remote sensing work SHORE Institute does: satellite-derived bathymetry, GeoAI classification, and the spatial data infrastructure under-resourced hydrographic offices need and cannot build alone.

This is where the funding-lead framing matters more than the announcement itself. Commonwealth SIDS funds of this kind route through national government applications, not direct NGO submissions, which means the actionable step is not "submit a proposal" but "get in front of the relevant ministry, in Seychelles' case likely the Department of Blue Economy or Ministry of Foreign Affairs, before the application window narrows." Given your prior role as Director General for Maritime Boundary Delimitation within that department, and SHORE's mandate, this is a lead worth working through existing relationships rather than a cold public call.

The counterpoint worth naming: \$200,000 per project, across a \$10 million fund shared by twenty-five states over five years, is a modest sum relative to the scale of the hydrospatial capacity gap Seychelles carries across 1.35 million square kilometres of EEZ. This is seed funding, not infrastructure funding. Its value is less in the amount and more in what a successful application demonstrates: proof of concept that can then be taken to larger blue finance instruments, Green Climate Fund windows, or bilateral partners, several of which look for exactly this kind of Commonwealth-endorsed pilot before committing larger sums.

The Apia Ocean Declaration angle is also worth tracking independently of the funding pool. It commits Commonwealth members to ocean governance actions Seychelles has already been ahead of, given the debt-for-nature marine spatial plan and the sovereign blue bond precedent. A project proposal that explicitly ties into Apia Declaration implementation, rather than framing itself as a generic climate resilience ask, is more likely to land in a fund built specifically to operationalise that declaration.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-collaboration-azerbaijan-launches-funding-sids>

 **DEADLINE 13 SEPTEMBER 2026**

// STORY_04

> unnf_fellowship --
deadline=12_days

This fellowship exists to build exactly the ocean governance capacity you spent a UNDP posting and a Director General role building, and the application window closes in under two weeks.

DEADLINE: 13 SEP 2026 • 12 DAYS FROM TODAY

STORY NOTES

\$ The UNNF Ocean Governance Fellowship for SIDS, backed by The Nippon Foundation and run through UN DOALOS, opened applications for its 2027 session, closing 13 September 2026. It targets government officials from SIDS building capacity in ocean governance and international legal frameworks, UNCLOS and BBNJ implementation specifically.

\$ The fellowship is structured for serving government officials rather than NGO staff, which narrows who can apply directly, but the more useful move is flagging it to counterparts still inside the Department of Blue Economy or the Ministry of Foreign Affairs where you previously worked.

<https://www.un.org/oceancapacity/content/unnf-ocean-governance-fellowship-sids>

STORY ARTICLE

Applications for the 2027 session of the UNNF Ocean Governance Fellowship for SIDS close on 13 September 2026, twelve days from today. The fellowship, run through the UN Division for Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea with funding from The Nippon Foundation, exists for a narrow purpose: building the capacity of small island developing state government officials to implement UNCLOS and the newer instruments sitting under it, BBNJ chief among them, at a moment when that implementation capacity is exactly what most SIDS delegations lack.

The programme is structured for serving government officials, not NGO or institute staff, which means SHORE cannot apply as an organisation. That is worth stating plainly rather than glossing over: this is not a direct funding or fellowship lead for you personally in your

current role. What it is, is a capacity pipeline for the people you used to sit alongside, and in some cases managed, when you held the Director General post for Maritime Boundary Delimitation. A fellowship class trained in BBNJ and UNCLOS implementation, sent back into Seychelles' Department of Blue Economy or Ministry of Foreign Affairs, is the kind of counterpart capacity that makes SHORE's technical work land with more institutional weight, not less.

The timing is not incidental. BBNJ entered into force in January 2026, and COP1 preparations are underway now, with rules of procedure, MPA nomination standards, and the ABS mechanism all still being negotiated. A fellowship cohort trained specifically in this period is being built to staff exactly that implementation phase. Historically, ocean governance fellowships of this type have produced durable professional networks: officials who move through the same cohort tend to stay in contact across subsequent COPs and negotiating sessions, which matters more for a small state's negotiating leverage than headcount does.

There is a fair critique of fellowship-based capacity building generally: it trains individuals rather than institutions, and when a trained official rotates out of government, as happens often in small administrations with thin succession benches, the capacity often leaves with them. That risk is real and worth naming to whoever you flag this to. It argues for nominating someone with an existing institutional anchor, ideally someone SHORE already has a working relationship with, rather than treating the fellowship as capacity-building in the abstract.

The action here is narrow and time-bound: forward the fellowship details to current contacts in the Department of Blue Economy or Foreign Affairs today, not after the 13 September deadline has passed. A fellowship class that includes a Seychelles official is a direct, low-cost way to

strengthen the government counterpart side of everything
SHORE and Shorelines argue for on the policy side.

<https://www.un.org/oceancapacity/content/unnf-ocean-governance-fellowship-sids>

STORY V

The High-Income SIDS Paradox, Confirmed by Two Institutions That Aren't You

This is your High-Income SIDS Paradox thesis, published back to you by ODI and CGD with Seychelles named directly as the graduation case study.

STORY NOTES

Between five and twelve SIDS are projected to lose ODA eligibility as they cross the World Bank's high-income threshold by 2030, Seychelles among the states that already graduated. Research from ODI and the Center for Global Development documents the pattern: graduation cuts concessional finance access before a state's structural vulnerability, exposure to climate shocks, thin tax base, small economy, actually changes.

SIDS carry average GDP losses over 50% from individual climate shocks despite contributing the least to global emissions, and manage 40% of the world's coral reefs and 30% of ocean real estate. Income-based graduation thresholds do not adjust for that exposure, which is the structural mismatch the paradox describes.

The fix under live discussion: multidimensional vulnerability indices replacing pure income thresholds for concessional finance eligibility.

<https://odi.org/en/publications/making-an-exception-maintaining-oda-eligibility-for-small-island-developing-states/>

STORY ARTICLE

Five to twelve small island developing states are projected to lose official development assistance eligibility as they cross the World Bank's high-income threshold by 2030. Seychelles crossed that threshold years ago and has lived the consequence since: concessional finance access narrowed sharply while the underlying exposure that made Seychelles eligible in the first place, a small, undiversified economy, a coastline entirely exposed to sea level rise and cyclone intensification, a tax base too thin to self-insure against disaster losses, did not change at all. Income went up. Vulnerability did not go down. The graduation criteria treat those as the same thing, and they are not.

This is the argument you have been making under the label "High-Income SIDS Paradox," and it is now showing up, independently argued, in research from the Overseas Development Institute and the Center for Global Development. Their framing lands on the same core claim: SIDS dependence on concessional finance stays high right up to the point of graduation, and without a transition mechanism, graduation causes measurable socio-economic setbacks rather than reflecting genuine development success. States that have already graduated show a consistent pattern afterward: concessional finance access drops sharply, disaster recovery gets financed through commercial borrowing at market rates instead, and debt distress follows within a small number of years.

The numbers behind the exposure side of this are stark and worth using precisely, not gesturally. SIDS as a group manage 40% of the world's coral reefs and 30% of all ocean real estate, and face average GDP losses exceeding 50% from individual climate shocks, categories most large-economy donors never experience at any scale. A metric built on income per capita, calculated at the national level, cannot see a shock that wipes out half a year's output in a single event, because averaged over the population it still reads as "high income."

The proposed fix under live discussion is a shift from pure income thresholds to multidimensional vulnerability indices, MVIs, that would weight climate exposure, economic narrowness, and disaster history alongside income when setting concessional eligibility. This is not a hypothetical academic proposal; UN member states have been negotiating MVI frameworks through the General Assembly process for several years, with SIDS delegations, Seychelles' among them historically, pushing hardest for adoption. The mechanism exists in draft form. What is missing is donor-side political will to actually apply it to eligibility decisions rather than treating it as a reporting supplement alongside the income metric that still governs actual money.

The counterargument, made mostly by donors managing finite ODA budgets, is that opening graduation criteria to vulnerability weighting risks an unbounded expansion of the eligible pool, since almost every country can claim some vulnerability dimension. That is a real budget-management concern, not a bad-faith one. But it is answerable: an MVI framework calibrated specifically to the SIDS category, rather than applied universally, does not open the door to advanced economies. It closes a gap that currently exists only for a small, defined group of states with a shared and measurable structural exposure.

This is close to a ready-made Shorelines piece: the case study is Seychelles, the data points are the ODI and CGD figures above plus whatever recent cyclone GDP-loss figure the Department of Blue Economy has on file, and the argument, that graduation criteria measure the wrong variable, is one you have made before informally and can now cite against two independent institutional sources making the identical claim.

Sources: ODI, "Making an exception: maintaining ODA eligibility for Small Island Developing States"; Center for Global Development, publication on ODA eligibility and graduation criteria, 2026.

<https://odi.org/en/publications/making-an-exception-maintaining-oda-eligibility-for-small-island-developing-states/>

China Has Charted Three Ocean Basins. Who Charts Yours?

China has run systematic bathymetric surveys through waters bordering states with far less survey capacity than its own, and that is precisely the asymmetry SHORE's hydrospatial sovereignty argument is built to name.

STORY NOTES

Reuters reporting, drawn from vessel tracking, documents at least 42 Chinese research vessels operating across the Pacific, Indian, and Arctic oceans over the past five years, conducting systematic seabed, salinity, and current surveys, including near chokepoints like the Malacca Strait. Some vessels disable tracking during these surveys, meaning the true extent is likely undercounted.

Naval analysts read the data collection as dual-use: the same bathymetric detail needed for civilian mapping supports submarine navigation and seabed sensor placement. In the Arctic, this intersects live territorial disputes among Russia, Canada, Denmark, Norway, and the US.

For Indian Ocean states without comparable survey fleets, the question this raises is not really about China specifically. It is about who controls the baseline data describing your own EEZ when your own hydrographic capacity cannot generate it independently.

[https://www.usnews.com/news/world/articles/2026-03-24/china-is-mapping-the-ocean-floor-as-it-prepares-for-submarine-warfare-with-the-u-s](https://www.usnews.com/news/world/articles/2026-03-24/china-is-mapping-the-ocean-floor-as-it-prepares-for-submarine-warfare-with-the-us)

STORY ARTICLE

At least 42 Chinese research vessels have conducted systematic bathymetric and oceanographic surveys across the Pacific, Indian, and Arctic oceans over the past five years, according to Reuters reporting built from vessel tracking data. Ships including the Dong Fang Hong 3, operated by Ocean University of China, have surveyed near Taiwan, Guam, Japan, and chokepoints including the Malacca Strait, gathering seabed terrain, water temperature, salinity, and current data at a level of detail well beyond what civilian navigation charts require. Some of these vessels disabled tracking during parts of these surveys, which means the reported scale is very likely a floor, not a ceiling.

Naval analysts are reading this as dual-use infrastructure building, not neutral science. The same bathymetric detail that supports fisheries management or climate research also supports submarine navigation, concealment terrain, and seabed sensor or cable placement, capabilities directly relevant to submarine warfare posture against the United States and its allies. In the Arctic specifically, where Russia, Canada, Denmark via Greenland, Norway, and the US hold overlapping and unresolved territorial claims, seabed mapping data has direct sovereignty implications rather than purely scientific ones.

Set the geopolitical framing aside for a moment and look at the structural point underneath it, because that is the one that applies regardless of which state is doing the surveying. A state's EEZ is defined and defended based on baseline data: bathymetry, seabed geomorphology, continental shelf extent claims under UNCLOS Article 76. When a state cannot generate that baseline data independently, because it lacks a blue-water research fleet, multibeam capacity, or a funded hydrographic office, whoever does generate the data effectively controls the evidentiary basis for that state's own maritime boundary claims. This is not hypothetical for Seychelles. The maritime boundary delimitation work Seychelles has pursued, including extended continental shelf claims, rests entirely on the quality and independence of the bathymetric survey data underpinning it.

This is the sharpest version of the argument for hydrospatial sovereignty as a governance concept, not just a technical one. A state that outsources its own seabed mapping, whether to a foreign government's research fleet, a commercial survey contractor, or simply gaps that never get filled, is outsourcing part of its capacity to defend its own maritime claims under UNCLOS. Seabed 2030's capacity-building model, discussed elsewhere in this edition, is one route to closing that gap on cooperative terms. The alternative, having the gap filled unilaterally by whichever state

has the fleet and the interest, is the scenario this story documents happening already, across three ocean basins, largely without the affected coastal states' visibility into what was collected or why.

The fair caveat: dual-use framing can tip into threat inflation, and civilian oceanographic research genuinely does require exactly this kind of systematic survey work, China's included. Not every Chinese research vessel transit is a security operation. But the tracking-disabled pattern, combined with the specific chokepoint and disputed-territory focus of the routes reported, makes a purely civilian-science reading hard to sustain as the complete explanation.

For Shorelines, the angle is not the US-China security framing every outlet covering this story has led with. It is the sovereignty-through-data-capacity argument: what it means for a small state's own maritime claims when the baseline data describing its waters is generated, and controlled, by someone else's fleet.

<https://www.usnews.com/news/world/articles/2026-03-24/china-is-mapping-the-ocean-floor-as-it-prepares-for-submarine-warfare-with-the-u-s>

07

Nineteen Bilateral Outcomes, and Blue Economy Was Named a Pillar

Modi's June 2026 visit produced nineteen bilateral outcomes touching blue economy and maritime cooperation directly, and that is the kind of concrete government-to-government commitment Shorelines readers need named, not summarised.

STORY NOTES

Indian PM Narendra Modi's state visit to Seychelles, 27–29 June 2026, produced nineteen bilateral outcomes spanning development finance, digital payments, maritime cooperation, agriculture, and institutional capacity-building. Fisheries and the broader blue economy were named explicitly as key pillars of the bilateral economic relationship.

Seychelles' tuna sector sits in the second-largest tuna basin globally, at roughly 20% of global tuna production, with Port Victoria handling around 80%

of the region's tuna catch. That existing scale is the backdrop against which the India cooperation commitments should be read: this is infrastructure and capacity layered onto an already-major fisheries economy, not a startup partnership.

<https://www.therightnews.in/2026/08/26/india-seychelles-recognise-fisheries-sector-broader-blue-economy-as-key-pillars-of-economic-growth/>

STORY ARTICLE

Nineteen bilateral outcomes came out of Narendra Modi's state visit to Seychelles from 27 to 29 June 2026, spanning development finance, digital payments infrastructure, maritime cooperation, agriculture, and institutional capacity-building. Fisheries and the wider blue economy were named explicitly, not folded into a general trade category, as key pillars of the bilateral economic relationship going forward.

The scale this sits on top of is worth stating precisely, because without it the announcement reads as more novel than it is. Seychelles operates in the second-largest tuna-producing basin in the world, accounting for roughly 20% of global tuna production, and Port Victoria handles approximately 80% of the region's tuna catch. This is not two states establishing a blue economy relationship from nothing. It is India formalising cooperation with an economy that already runs one of the world's most significant tuna fisheries hubs, and the commitments announced, digital payments

infrastructure among them, read as capacity and efficiency layers on existing fisheries and port operations rather than new-sector development.

What is less clear from the coverage available is the specific mechanism behind the maritime cooperation and blue economy commitments: whether this involves hydrographic survey cooperation, vessel monitoring technology transfer, port infrastructure financing, or fisheries management capacity-building, each of which has a very different relevance to SHORE's work. India has separately pursued blue economy partnerships across the Indian Ocean region with a consistent pattern of infrastructure financing paired with maritime domain awareness capability, satellite and vessel tracking systems specifically, so that pairing is a reasonable working assumption pending the detailed bilateral texts.

The prior Seychelles blue economy record gives this cooperation a credible foundation to build on rather than a blank slate. Seychelles pioneered the world's first sovereign blue bond, alongside a debt-for-nature swap that funded a full marine spatial plan of its EEZ and designated 30% of it as marine protected area, well ahead of most peer SIDS. A bilateral partnership that plugs into that existing framework, rather than proposing a parallel one, would represent real continuity. One that does not risks adding institutional complexity without adding capacity, a familiar failure mode in bilateral blue economy cooperation generally, where announced partnerships proliferate faster than any single government's capacity to coordinate them.

The open question worth tracking for Shorelines: does the India cooperation route through the Department of Blue Economy's existing marine spatial plan and blue bond framework, or does it stand up separately? That answer determines whether this is capacity Seychelles can actually absorb and use, or another bilateral commitment layered on top of an already busy coordination landscape.

<https://www.therightnews.in/2026/08/26/india-seychelles-recognise-fisheries-sector-broader-blue-economy-as-key-pillars-of-economic-growth/>

A Forum Dedicated to Ocean Finance, Inside the UNFCCC Itself

“A formal push for blue investment that would have been unthinkable a decade ago.”

A dedicated UNFCCC finance forum for ocean and water systems convenes in three weeks, and blue finance getting its own agenda slot at all is the institutional opening SIDS have been arguing for since before you started tracking this.

STORY NOTES

The UNFCCC Standing Committee on Finance is convening a forum dedicated to finance action for water systems and the ocean on 21-22 September 2026. Ocean finance getting a dedicated forum slot inside the core UNFCCC finance architecture, rather than as a side conversation, is a real shift in institutional status.

This sits alongside the broader pattern from the June 2026 Ocean and Climate Change Dialogue: SIDS parties, Seychelles among them, have consistently framed ocean-related NDC actions as conditional on external support, because the finance to act on

those commitments has largely not existed inside the formal UNFCCC finance mechanisms until now.

https://unfccc.int/sites/default/files/resource/Ocean_Dialogue_2026_Information_Note.pdf

STORY ARTICLE

The UNFCCC Standing Committee on Finance convenes a forum dedicated specifically to finance action for water systems and the ocean on 21 and 22 September 2026, three weeks from today. That a dedicated ocean finance forum exists inside the Standing Committee's own agenda, rather than as a side event running parallel to the main finance negotiations, is itself the news. Ocean finance has spent most of the UNFCCC process as an implied category inside broader adaptation finance, discussed but never structurally prioritised. A named forum with its own agenda slot is a different institutional status entirely.

The context that makes this forum matter comes out of the June 2026 Ocean and Climate Change Dialogue, where a consistent pattern showed up across submissions: SIDS parties, Seychelles' among them historically, have framed their ocean-related Nationally Determined Contribution actions as conditional on external support. That is a specific and important distinction from framing them as aspirational or optional. Conditional means the commitment exists on paper and the finance to execute it does not, which has been the practical reality of ocean-related NDC commitments for most SIDS since NDCs started including ocean content at all.

Put the exposure numbers next to that conditionality framing and the stakes get concrete. SIDS manage 40% of the world's coral reefs and 30% of all ocean real estate, contribute the least of any country grouping to global emissions, and face average GDP losses exceeding 50% from individual climate-related shocks. A forum that treats ocean and water finance as a first-order UNFCCC finance category, rather than an implied subset of adaptation finance generally, is the mechanism through which that conditionality gap could actually start closing, if the forum produces a finance instrument or facility rather than a discussion output.

That "if" is the real test, and it is worth naming rather than assuming away. UNFCCC finance forums have a long history of producing well-attended discussions that do not convert into disbursable instruments; the Green Climate Fund itself took years between initial UNFCCC discussion and operational disbursement capacity. A forum dedicated to ocean finance is a necessary institutional step, not a sufficient one. What determines whether September's forum matters in practice is whether it produces a defined

facility, a funding window, or a concrete allocation mechanism, versus a set of statements reaffirming ocean finance's importance without a route to money attached.

For Shorelines, this is worth a short piece the week of 21–22 September itself, once the forum's actual outputs are public, rather than a preview piece now. The preview risks restating the conditionality problem everyone already knows. The piece that matters is whether this specific forum changed the mechanism, or just repeated the diagnosis for the fourth or fifth time since ocean-climate finance became a named UNFCCC concern.

https://unfccc.int/sites/default/files/resource/Ocean_Dialogue_2026_Information_Note.pdf

09 Funding the Part of a High Seas MPA That Actually Has to Work

TNC's new commitment funds exactly the enabling conditions, financing, monitoring, marine spatial planning systems, that determine whether the first generation of high seas MPAs actually functions or just exists on paper.

STORY NOTES

The Nature Conservancy submitted a new commitment at the Our Ocean Conference to support development and early implementation of the first generation of high seas marine protected areas under BBNJ, focused on financing, monitoring, compliance, and marine spatial planning systems, the enabling conditions rather than the MPA designations themselves.

This builds on the BBNJ Symposium series, Edinburgh 2023, Singapore 2025, Brazil 2026, an independent forum bringing governments, NGOs, industry, and academia together specifically on implementation questions, running alongside the formal COP process rather than inside it.

<https://www.nature.org/en-us/newsroom/tnc-our-ocean-conference-high-seas-commitment/>

STORY ARTICLE

The Nature Conservancy has submitted a new Our Ocean Conference commitment to support the development and early implementation of the first generation of high seas marine protected areas designated under BBNJ. The commitment's focus is instructive: financing, monitoring, compliance, and marine spatial planning systems, the enabling infrastructure an MPA needs to function, rather than funding for the designation process itself. That distinction matters more than it might initially read.

A marine protected area designated on paper and a marine protected area with an actual monitoring and compliance system behind it are functionally different instruments, and the gap between them is where most MPA commitments globally have historically failed to deliver protection outcomes matching their stated coverage targets. High seas MPAs face this problem in an especially acute form, because there is no coastal state with jurisdiction to enforce compliance directly; enforcement in areas beyond national jurisdiction depends entirely on whatever monitoring and reporting architecture the BBNJ framework and its parties build collectively. A financing commitment aimed specifically at that architecture, rather than at MPA area totals, is targeting the part of the system genuinely likely to determine whether BBNJ's high seas MPA provisions produce real protection or produce area statistics.

This sits alongside a parallel and less formal track worth tracking independently: the BBNJ Symposium series, launched in Edinburgh in 2023, continued in Singapore in 2025, and held in Brazil in 2026. Unlike the formal COP process, this symposium series exists specifically as a cross-sector forum, governments, NGOs, industry, and academia together, focused on implementation questions rather than treaty text negotiation. That

structure makes it a more accessible entry point for an organisation like SHORE than the formal COP process, where state party status governs participation far more strictly.

Marine spatial planning is the specific technical layer where SHORE's hydrospatial work connects directly to this financing commitment. High seas MPA planning requires exactly the kind of spatial data infrastructure, bathymetric baseline, habitat mapping, spatial data sovereignty questions, that Seychelles has been building through its own EEZ marine spatial plan since the debt-for-nature swap. The technical methodology transfers, even though the jurisdiction, areas beyond national jurisdiction rather than a national EEZ, is entirely different. A funder specifically resourcing MSP systems for high seas MPAs is a funder whose technical requirements SHORE's existing capability maps onto closely.

The honest caveat: TNC's commitment is a pledge of support, not yet a disbursed grant programme with an application process, and the mechanism for how organisations like SHORE could plug into it is not yet public. This is a relationship to open now, likely through the BBNJ Symposium network itself, rather than a funding call to apply to yet.

<https://www.nature.org/en-us/newsroom/tnc-our-ocean-conference-high-seas-commitment/>

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21.1°C, and the Sink Underneath Every Story in This Edition

Sea surface temperature hit a record 21.1°C this year, and an ailing ocean carbon sink is the physical baseline every governance and finance argument in this edition assumes is stable.

STORY NOTES

Global average sea surface temperature reached a record 21.1°C according to Copernicus Climate Change Service data, part of a broader pattern researchers at Lamont-Doherty Earth Observatory describe as an ailing ocean carbon sink, the ocean's capacity to absorb atmospheric CO₂ showing signs of measurable decline.

This is the physical layer underneath every governance and finance story in this edition. BBNJ's MPA provisions, Seabed 2030's mapping targets, the SIDS finance conditionality argument, all assume a reasonably stable baseline ocean system to manage. A weakening carbon sink and record warming complicate that assumption.

<https://lamont.columbia.edu/news/ocean-carbon-sink-ailing>

STORY ARTICLE

Global average sea surface temperature reached a record 21.1°C this year, according to data from the EU's Copernicus Climate Change Service. That single number sits on top of a more structurally concerning finding from researchers at Columbia's Lamont-Doherty Earth Observatory: the ocean carbon sink, the mechanism by which the ocean absorbs a substantial share of humanity's atmospheric CO₂ output, is showing measurable signs of decline in its absorption efficiency.

Put those two findings together and the implication runs directly under every governance story in this edition, without qualification. BBNJ's high seas MPA framework, Seabed 2030's mapping targets, Seychelles' own marine spatial plan, all of it assumes a reference ocean system that changes slowly enough for management instruments designed on multi-year and multi-decade timelines to keep pace. A record sea surface temperature paired with declining carbon sink efficiency is evidence against that assumption, not confirmation of it.

This matters specifically for hydrospatial work in a way that is easy to overlook if you treat ocean warming as a climate story rather than a mapping one. Warming sea surface temperature drives thermal expansion and shifts to circulation patterns, both of which affect the baseline data that bathymetric and habitat mapping efforts rely on as stable reference points. A marine spatial plan built on a static baseline, in a system where the baseline itself is measurably moving, needs a revision cadence built into its governance from the start, not as an afterthought once the plan is judged out of date.

The carbon sink finding carries a second-order implication worth naming directly, because it touches ocean governance debates currently live at BBNJ and elsewhere: marine carbon dioxide removal, mCDR, is being proposed and piloted as a partial response to declining natural sink capacity, and BBNJ's environmental impact assessment provisions are one of the few binding frameworks positioned to govern mCDR activity in the high seas specifically. A 2026 policy brief from the Ocean & Climate Platform argues precaution should guide mCDR research and governance given how little is understood about the ecological consequences of large-scale ocean carbon manipulation. That argument gets sharper, not weaker, as the natural sink these interventions would supplement

shows signs of decline rather than stability.

The honest tension to hold here: an ailing natural carbon sink strengthens the case for research into engineered alternatives, while simultaneously making the precautionary argument against deploying those alternatives at scale before they are properly understood more urgent, not less. Both readings are correct at once, and any Shorelines piece on mCDR governance needs to hold that tension rather than resolving it prematurely in either direction.

For your own work, the actionable read is narrower and more immediate: any marine spatial plan or hydrosatial baseline SHORE produces for Seychelles waters should be built with an explicit revision timeline, tied to sea surface temperature and circulation monitoring, rather than treated as a static reference document. The data underneath BBNJ, Seabed 2030, and Seychelles' own EEZ plan is moving faster than the governance instruments built on top of it assume.

<https://lamont.columbia.edu/news/ocean-carbon-sink-ailing>

